

**CLEARING THE GROUND:
CULTIVATING THE HEART THROUGH THE LOWER LEVELS
OF INTERNALIZATION—RECEIVING, RESPONDING, AND VALUING**

Abstract. This article is the third in a series. Where the first diagnosed why spiritual maturity resists measurement and the second prescribed a cultivation matched to each transition of the affective taxonomy, the present article descends into the lower three levels—Receiving, Responding, and Valuing—where the great majority of formation actually takes place and where, as the second article argued, the decisive duty-to-desire threshold lies. Drawing throughout on the Intentional Journey of the Heart corpus and its small-group ministry, the Fellowship of the Heart, it argues three things. First, that formation in the lower levels is mostly clearing rather than building: breaking hard ground, deepening shallow roots, and removing the thorns the

corpus names as emotional knots. Second, that the soils of the Sower are best read not as four kinds of people, nor as four stages of one life, but as four conditions co-present in a single heart—a reading that dissolves the developmental-ladder objection and grounds the integration-not-replacement account of the taxonomy. Third, that the threshold into Valuing is crossed not by pressure but by clearing what chokes desire, scaffolding the practice of hearing, and being honestly known in community. It develops a clearing-tool pedagogy matched to soil condition and illustrates it by the Fellowship’s ten-week Getting Started curriculum, whose stated aim is to bring a cohort “to the threshold of the Level 2-to-Level 3 transition.” It further extends the soil map downward to a Level -1—active opposition to others’ receiving of the word—where the Companion’s task becomes discernment and, in community, spiritual warfare, and where the Companion’s own life under spiritual direction and within a Fellowship-of-the-Heart community proves not best practice but existential necessity. Throughout it holds the boundary its companions hold: the tools clear the ground; the Spirit gives the growth.

Keywords. spiritual formation; affective domain taxonomy; Parable of the Sower; emotional knots; means of grace; small-group discipleship; hearing God

Introduction: Where Formation Actually Happens

Two companion studies frame this one. The first argued that consensus on measuring spiritual maturity has proven elusive because existing instruments conflate the levels of affective internalization, clustering at the lower levels while the construct they claim to assess lives at the higher ones. The second turned from diagnosis to cultivation, proposing that each transition between levels has a characteristic barrier and therefore a characteristic intervention—and that the failure of much formation is a failure to match the two.¹ Both ranged across all five levels at altitude. This article descends, deliberately and at length, into the lower three: Receiving, Responding, and Valuing.

The descent is not a step down in importance. It is a step toward where formation actually happens. The great majority of people, the great majority of the time, are somewhere in the lower three levels; it is there that assessment instruments cluster, there that congregational ministry concentrates, and there—at the passage from Responding into Valuing—that both companion studies located the single decisive threshold of the whole arc. It is also where most formational effort goes wrong, either by applying pressure that hardens the very ground it means to open, or by mistaking the lower-level behaviors a person can perform for the inner change only the Spirit can give.

The argument has the advantage of a worked example. Its applied material is drawn throughout from a single body of work: the *Intentional Journey of the Heart* (IJH), a corpus that

¹This is the third in a series. The first, “Measuring Spiritual Maturity in Hearing God: An Affective Domain Taxonomy for Individual and Small-Group Internalization” (hereafter “Measuring Spiritual Maturity”), is diagnostic; the second, “Cultivating Spiritual Maturity in Hearing God: An Affective-Domain Pedagogy of Formation for Individuals and Small Groups” (hereafter “Cultivating Spiritual Maturity”), is prescriptive across all five levels. The present article descends into the lower three. On the underlying taxonomy, see David R. Krathwohl, Benjamin S. Bloom, and Bertram B. Masia, *Taxonomy of Educational Objectives: The Classification of Educational Goals; Handbook II: Affective Domain* (New York: David McKay, 1964).

formalizes a theology of hearing and obeying God, and its small-group ministry, the *Fellowship of the Heart* (FotH), whose entry-level curriculum is designed for precisely the band this article treats.² The corpus supplies what the second companion study could only gesture at: a concrete account of what blocks the lower transitions and what clears them. The thesis that emerges is that in the lower levels, cultivation is mostly *clearing*—and that the right clearing depends on reading the ground correctly. One boundary governs the whole, the same boundary the companion studies observe: every clearing here tends conditions; it does not manufacture growth. As the corpus puts it of its own practices, “the tools help create the conditions for the Spirit to work.”

The Soil Is One Heart

The second companion study, reading the Parable of the Sower, had to guard against a known objection: that the four soils are four kinds of hearers, not four stages of one life, and that to make them a developmental ladder is to over-allegorize. The IJH corpus resolves the difficulty with a reframe more searching than either the “four kinds of people” reading or the “four stages” reading. The four soils, it proposes, “describe four conditions of my own heart at any given moment—not four categories of people, but four regions of a person’s interior landscape.”³ I am not the rocky soil. Parts of me are good soil; parts are thorny; parts, if I am honest, are still the hard path. The question is not *which soil am I* but *what is the current condition of each part of my heart, and which parts are blocking the fruit the word should be producing*.

²The applied material throughout is drawn from two bodies of work by the same author: the *Intentional Journey of the Heart* (hereafter IJH), a multi-volume corpus formalizing a theology of hearing and obeying God; and the *Fellowship of the Heart* (hereafter FotH), its small-group ministry. Both are cited here as a working corpus; full publication details to be supplied.

³IJH, Vol. 2, *From Knowing to Doing*, Exploration 1 (“The Heart Soil”). The reading is stated there: “the four soil types describe four conditions of my own heart at any given moment—not four categories of people, but four regions of a person’s interior landscape.”

This single move does a great deal of work. It dissolves the ladder objection at a stroke: nothing is being claimed about a person climbing cleanly from soil to soil, because the soils are not sequential positions but simultaneous regions. It converts the parable from a sorting mechanism into a diagnostic mirror—the use the corpus makes its governing law: “the four soil types... describe four conditions of the human heart, not just four categories of people,” and the diagnostic task is to “match the right clearing tool to the right soil problem.”⁴ That phrase is the lower-level cousin of the second study’s rule, *match the intervention to the transition*: here, *match the clearing tool to the soil*.

It also grounds, from below, the most important calibration the corpus places on the taxonomy: that maturity is integration, not replacement. “The operational target of formation is not stage replacement,” the corpus states; “it is the increasing integration of all five stages such that all remain simultaneously alive in the formed person.” A person who has “outgrown” the openness of Receiving is not advanced but “rigid.”⁵ Read as regions of one heart, the soils make this concrete: good soil in one area does not retire the hard path in another, and the goal is never to leave Receiving behind but to keep every region open to the Word. The lower levels, then, are not a vestibule one passes through and forgets. They are ground that must stay cleared. A further document in the corpus reads the same four conditions as attachment-pattern signatures—the

⁴IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 1, *Proposed Law (Diagnostic)*: “The four soil types in the parable of the Sower describe four conditions of the human heart, not just four categories of people... match the right clearing tool to the right soil problem.” The corpus’s foundational paper, *A Model of Spiritual Formation for Individuals and Small Groups* (MSFIG), names the Parable of the Sower as “the primary scriptural test of the Affective Taxonomy.”

⁵IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 7 (“Hearing with Understanding”), section “Reading These Levels as Integration, Not Replacement” (the pastoral statement), and Vol. 4, “Testing Framework,” §2 (the construct-level statement): “the operational target of formation is not stage replacement. It is the increasing integration of all five stages such that all remain simultaneously alive in the formed person.” Cf. “Cultivating Spiritual Maturity,” on the same point.

hard path as avoidant, the rocky soil as anxious, the thorny soil as disorganized, the good soil as secure—locating the most stubborn lower-level thorns in the relational substrate beneath them.⁶

Receiving, Responding, Valuing—and the Threshold

The three levels in view are defined, in the corpus as in the taxonomy, by the source and depth of motivation. *Receiving* is bare, willing attention: the person “shows up, listens, reads the passage, and participates at a surface level,” but “motivation is entirely external.” *Responding* is active, sustained engagement—joining the discussion, completing the readings, praying when the group prays—where “the motivation is still largely external,” so that the practice “largely stops when the external structure stops.” *Valuing* is the shift the whole lower arc is bending toward: “the transition from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation... ‘I hear God’s Word because I have discovered that it is worth my time and is changing my life.’” It is, in the corpus’s image, “the floor of good soil, the 30-fold harvest.”⁷

The boundary between Responding and Valuing is the hinge of this article, as it was of its predecessor. Both bodies of work converge on it independently: the corpus calls it “the most critical and challenging threshold in the entire taxonomy, where competing values test emerging intrinsic motivation.”⁸ Everything below it can be scaffolded from outside; nothing above it can.

⁶The named IJH Formation Documents are TA (*Theological Anthropology*), HFT (*Heart Formation Theology*), SST (*Soul and Spirit Taxonomies*), MSFIG (*A Model of Spiritual Formation for Individuals and Small Groups*), FC (*The Formation Companion*), 4Cs (*The Four Connects*), MSF (*Measuring Spiritual Formation at Scale*), and ATB (*Attachment Theory and the Biblical Triad*). HFT and MSFIG carry the Sower-to-taxonomy mapping; ATB proposes a parallel mapping of the four soils to attachment patterns (hard path ↔ avoidant; rocky ↔ anxious; thorny ↔ disorganized; good ↔ secure).

⁷IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 7: “Level 1—Receiving... bare awareness; willingness to attend... Motivation is entirely external”; “Level 2—Responding... active engagement; following through when prompted... motivation is still largely external”; “Level 3—Valuing... the transition from extrinsic to intrinsic motivation... the floor of good soil, the 30-fold harvest.”

⁸Both IJH (Vol. 2, Exp. 1; Vol. 4, §2) and “Cultivating Spiritual Maturity” identify the Responding-to-Valuing passage as the decisive one. IJH calls it “the most critical and challenging threshold in the entire taxonomy, where competing values test emerging intrinsic motivation.”

To reach Valuing is to have crossed from a practice the world sustains to a practice the heart sustains—and that crossing, as the next sections argue, is achieved far less by adding desire than by removing what was choking it.

Two cautions, drawn from the corpus, govern the lower work. The first is that the levels integrate rather than replace, and this has a direct pastoral consequence: it is better to reach Responding with Receiving still alive than to skip openness in order to perform engagement. The Companions state the ethic plainly—“a participant who reaches Level 2 (Responding) with genuine Level 1 Receiving still alive is sturdier than one who has skipped past Level 1’s openness in order to perform Level 2’s engagement.”⁹ The second caution is the lower-level form of the Pharisee problem. Under the integration reading, the Pharisee is not a person stuck at a level but “the form any level takes when its earlier-stage openness has collapsed.” Its lower-level shapes are recognizable: “Pharisee-Receiving collapse is sectarianism” (“I don’t need to hear that”); “Pharisee-Responding collapse is debate culture,” in which every engagement returns to defending what is already settled.¹⁰ The danger in the lower levels is not only failing to advance but advancing in a way that quietly hardens the ground.

Clearing the Hard Path (toward Receiving)

The hard path cannot receive the seed; the soil itself must be opened before anything else can be attempted. Two cultivations belong to this transition, one before the cohort gathers and one as it gathers. The first is an honest entry. The Companion does not recruit but discerns. Its

⁹FotH, “Getting Started,” *Companion’s Handbook*, §1: “a participant who reaches Level 2 (Responding) with genuine Level 1 Receiving still alive is sturdier than one who has skipped past Level 1’s openness in order to perform Level 2’s engagement.”

¹⁰IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 7: the Pharisee is “the form any level takes when its earlier-stage openness has collapsed”—“Pharisee-Receiving collapse is sectarianism... Pharisee-Responding collapse is debate culture... Pharisee-Valuing collapse is moral grandstanding.” “Jesus’ Matt. 23 indictment names all five at once.”

pre-cohort conversation offers three equally honored outcomes—“yes-and-ready, yes-but-not-yet, no-and-honest”—and protects decline as a real option, on the conviction that “a cohort of 8 people who said yes honestly is a stronger cohort than a cohort of 12 people where 4 said yes under pressure.”¹¹ This is Receiving taken seriously at the door: genuine willingness to attend cannot be manufactured by enrollment, and a coerced yes is hard ground dressed as good. The Companions even teach their people to say the true thing about their own motivation—“if you’re here because Mom said you had to be, that is a true sentence. Say that.” Named honestly, bare external motivation is not a disqualification; it is the floor of Receiving, and a ground the Spirit can work.

The second cultivation is the container. Before the word can land, there must be a space in which landing is possible, and the Companion builds one deliberately: a relational vessel defined by four conditions Safe, Present, Clear, Intentional re-established every session with a spoken commitment, “I am here. I am paying attention. I am willing to be moved.”¹² The container is to the group what plowing is to the soil: it does not produce the harvest, but without it the seed never gets below the surface. And here the gardener’s limit is starkest. Conviction, honest exposure, the plow of the law, the disorienting witness of changed lives all may be applied; none softens a heart. That remains a divine prerogative, and so the plowing of this transition is inseparable from intercession: we break what ground we can reach and pray for the rain we cannot send.¹³

¹¹FotH, “Getting Started,” *Pre-Cohort Discernment Guide*: three honored outcomes—“yes-and-ready, yes-but-not-yet, no-and-honest.” “A cohort of 8 people who said yes honestly is a stronger cohort than a cohort of 12 people where 4 said yes under pressure.”

¹²FotH, “Getting Started,” *Companion’s Handbook*, §5 (“The Container”): its four conditions are Safe, Present, Clear, and Intentional, re-opened each session with the spoken commitment, “I am here. I am paying attention. I am willing to be moved.”

¹³Ezek 36:26; cf. “Cultivating Spiritual Maturity,” on the fallow-ground transition: the gardener may drive the plow but cannot soften the heart, which is a divine prerogative.

Contested Ground: Active Opposition and the Companion's Warfare (Level -1)

The map of soils has, to this point, bottomed out at the hard path—the ground that does not receive. But beneath the passive hardness of the path lies a more troubling condition, and the corpus's own reading of the parable forces us to name it. The hard path is not merely closed; it is closed because, in Jesus' words, "when anyone hears... the evil one comes and snatches away what has been sown" (Matt 13:19; cf. Mark 4:15). "The adversary is not passive in the Sower parable," the corpus observes; "he is active at the point of reception."¹⁴ Most often that activity works on a single heart, through the lies that install and sustain its knots. But it has a further reach. There are people in whom the opposition has hardened from passivity into agency—who labor, wittingly or not, to keep not only themselves but others from receiving the word. Below Level 0, the hardheartedness that will not receive, lies a Level -1: the active obstruction of reception, in oneself and in others.

Scripture names the human form of this sharply. Jesus' severest woe falls not on the immoral but on those who "shut the kingdom of heaven in people's faces," who "neither enter" themselves "nor allow those who would enter to go in" (Matt 23:13). It is the most militant form of what this article has already called the Pharisee-Receiving collapse, sectarianism—"I don't need to hear that" hardened into "and I will see that you do not either." It is, in the corpus's own terms, a calling turned inside out: every genuine calling has "a shadow mission—its exact dark mirror," which "wastes the same gifts" and "sends [them] in the opposite direction," and at its extreme a gifted person's shadow turns those very gifts against what the kingdom builds.¹⁵ Two

¹⁴ IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 2B ("The Adversary's Role"): "the adversary is not passive in the Sower parable... he is active at the point of reception" (cf. Mark 4:15). The lies that install and sustain a knot have "a source... the wound provided the entry point; the enemy provided the interpretation."

¹⁵ IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 5 ("The Four Connects"): every calling has "a shadow mission—its exact dark mirror," which "wastes the same gifts" and "sends [them] in the opposite direction." The form Jesus names most sharply is the one

cautions must hold the diagnosis open. First, Level -1 is a condition, not a verdict: Saul of Tarsus was Level -1—“breathing threats and murder,” dragging others from the faith—and became Paul, so that the warfare proper to this condition is always for the person and never against them. The opponent, the corpus insists with Paul, is finally never the human being: “we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against... the spiritual forces of evil” (Eph 6:12). Second, the diagnosis is easily abused, and here the corpus is conspicuously careful, preferring “to err on the side of understatement” against any “theatrical” warfare framing that would explain away a person’s own responsibility or turn ordinary hardness into a demonic drama.¹⁶

The Companion’s first task before suspected opposition is therefore the most consequential discernment in the lower-level repertoire: to tell a Level 0 heart that is merely hard from a Level -1 situation in which the ground is being actively contested—and to do so without rushing to either reading. The misreadings are costly in opposite directions. To treat a merely hard or wounded heart as a demonic stronghold is to wound a person, manufacture an enemy, and excuse them from their own work; the corpus is emphatic that “naming the adversary accurately neither reduces my responsibility for the work nor inflates the adversary’s power.”¹⁷ But to treat genuine active opposition as ordinary hardness is to go on scattering seed onto ground that is being guarded against it and, worse, to leave undefended the others whom that opposition targets. This is the downward extension of the article’s governing rule—match the

who would “shut the kingdom of heaven in people’s faces,” who “neither enter... nor allow those who would enter to go in” (Matt 23:13).

¹⁶ IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 2B, on Eph 6:12: “the wrestling is real, and the opponent is not human.” The corpus deliberately “err[s] on the side of understatement,” warning against a “theatrical” warfare framing that would excuse a person from their own work. That Level -1 is a condition and not a verdict is shown by Saul of Tarsus (Acts 8:3; 9:1), who became Paul.

¹⁷ IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 2B, *Proposed Law (Diagnostic)*: knots “do not form in a neutral environment”; the clearing work is “a recovery of ground that is being actively contested,” and “naming the adversary accurately neither reduces my responsibility for the work nor inflates the adversary’s power—it clarifies the actual nature of the contest.”

response to the condition—into its gravest register: read the contest truly before bringing any tool to it.

Where the discernment lands on genuine opposition, the response is spiritual warfare—but warfare strictly as the New Testament defines it, which is neither argument nor force nor theatrics. Its weapons “are not of the flesh but have divine power to destroy strongholds” (2 Cor 10:4): prayer, the armor of God, truth spoken plainly, and the authority of Christ invoked on behalf of the contested person and against the powers behind the opposition (Eph 6:10–18). The corpus’s own observation is that clearing work which names the contest honestly “tends to produce more durable results than the same process done without it.”¹⁸ But the decisive condition is one the corpus’s account of the adversary makes unavoidable: this is never solo work. The enemy, in the corpus’s image of the prowling lion, “targets the isolatable, the already wounded, the one who has drifted from community,” and “separates him from the group before striking” (1 Pet 5:8). A Companion who engages active spiritual opposition while isolated is therefore not a warrior but a target. The point is existential, not procedural. The Companion who would discern and contest Level -1 ground on another’s behalf must first be a person who is themselves under spiritual direction and inside a Fellowship-of-the-Heart community of their own—companioned, confessed over, prayed for, accountable. The standing rule of the corpus becomes here a matter of survival: “every Companion has a Companion... a Companion who has stopped growing is heading for a ditch.”¹⁹ The sons of Sceva, who tried to wield a name they had

¹⁸ 2 Cor 10:3–5; Eph 6:10–18. IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 2B, observes that clearing work which names the contest honestly—“not dramatic or theatrical, but honest and direct”—“tends to produce more durable results than the same process done without it.”

¹⁹ IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 2B, on 1 Pet 5:8: the adversary “targets the isolatable, the already wounded, the one who has drifted from community,” and “separates him from the group before striking.” Hence the Companion’s own covering is load-bearing: FotH, *Companion’s Handbook*—“Every Companion has a Companion... a Companion who has stopped growing is heading for a ditch.”

not submitted to and were overpowered and fled (Acts 19:13–16), are the New Testament’s own statement of the same law: no one contests these powers on borrowed authority, or alone.²⁰

Deepening the Rocky Ground (Receiving into Responding)

The rocky-ground heart has received the word and responded with real, even joyful, energy; its failure is rootlessness a response sustained from outside that collapses when the outside support is withdrawn. The cultivation proper to it is the application of rhythm, and the Companions’ account of rhythm corrects the two errors that usually attend it. Against the perfectionism that abandons a practice at the first lapse, it preaches returning rather than streaks: “Streaks are not the goal. Returning is the goal. The pattern of returning, over years, is what shapes a life.” Its durable core is deliberately small—a morning question (“Father, what are you up to today—and what do you want me to notice?”) and a one-sentence evening note (“Where did I see God today?”), with “I did not see him today” counted a complete entry.²¹ The scaffold is mechanical by design; regularity precedes delight, and a rhythm one can fail and resume is a rhythm that can build a root.

Two things keep this scaffolding from curing into a permanent externality. The first is that the central practice is hearing, not mere habit. The Companions’ hearing discipline, PROAPT—pray, read, observe, apply, pray again, tell—is taught as “a hearing practice, not a Bible-study technique,” and its logic is the corpus’s hearing chain: the word is the input, hearing

²⁰ Acts 19:13–16 (the sons of Sceva): those who tried to invoke the name of Jesus without submission to him “were overpowered” and fled—the New Testament’s own warning that these powers are not contested on borrowed authority, or alone.

²¹ FotH, “Getting Started,” *Rhythm Card*: “Streaks are not the goal. Returning is the goal. The pattern of returning, over years, is what shapes a life.” The card’s daily core is a morning question (“Father, what are you up to today—and what do you want me to notice?”) and a one-sentence evening note (“Where did I see God today?”).

is the conversion mechanism, faith is the output.²² Scaffolding the practice of hearing is scaffolding the very faculty whose intrinsic exercise will, at the next threshold, become Valuing. The second is that the root the rocky ground lacks is grown less in private discipline than in being known. The corpus's formation architecture begins not with God-directed practice but with self-knowledge tested in community: one tells one's story, repeatedly, to a few who can reflect it back, because "the self you are connecting with is partly constructed through being witnessed by others. You cannot see all of yourself from inside yourself."²³ The rocky-ground believer is often alone with an unexamined interior; the root deepens when the story is heard.

Removing the Thorns: The Knot and the Threshold into Valuing

The thorny ground is where the lower-level work concentrates, because the thorns guard the decisive threshold. The corpus's account of them is its most distinctive contribution to a formation pedagogy, and it is more precise than the parable's surface. The thorns "are not sin in the simple sense—they are competing energetic loads." The word has genuinely taken root; something is growing; but the available energy and attention are being consumed elsewhere, and the result is no fruit. The corpus names the condition an *emotional knot*: "a sustained energetic load on the heart, created by an unresolved wound, an incomplete communication, or a lie believed."²⁴ This reframes the threshold into Valuing in a way that changes the cultivation

²²FotH, "Getting Started," *PROAPT Card*: Pray, Read, Observe, Apply, Pray-again, Tell—"a hearing practice, not a Bible-study technique." Its operative chain (Word → Hearing → Faith) is the IJH hearing chain: see IJH, Vol. 1, *Laws of the Spirit*, Exp. 1 ("How to Get Faith," on Rom 10:17): "Hearing... is the conversion mechanism. Faith... is the output."

²³IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 5 ("The Four Connects"): "the self you are connecting with is partly constructed through being witnessed by others. You cannot see all of yourself from inside yourself." The four Connects—Self, Others, God, Mission—are derived from Matt 22:37–39 and run as "a causal sequence with directional dependencies."

²⁴IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 2 ("Emotional Knots"): "An emotional knot is a sustained energetic load on the heart, created by an unresolved wound, an incomplete communication, or a lie believed." The thorny soil "is the most important category for Vol 2's purposes... the thorns are not sin in the simple sense—they are competing energetic loads."

entirely. What looks, at the rocky-to-good passage, like an absence of desire is frequently a presence of obstruction—desire choked rather than missing. The work is therefore not to summon desire but to clear the thorns that are eating its fuel.

Clearing requires first a diagnosis the corpus insists upon: is this obstacle a sin or a weight? The distinction is drawn from a single text—“let us also lay aside every weight, and sin which clings so closely” (Heb 12:1)—and it is load-bearing: “Sin is confessed. Weight is laid aside.” The two are cleared by different means, and applying the wrong one accomplishes nothing.²⁵ Beneath most knots lies a cognitive root: “every emotional knot has a cognitive root—a belief about God, about myself, or about others that is false,” often hardened, through repetition, into “the vow... the wound hardened into policy.”²⁶ The men’s-formation lineage the corpus draws on locates one such root with unusual precision: a core question the wound installs and the adversary exploits—some version of “Do I have what it takes?”—which no argument settles and only the Father’s direct, personal answer can finally still (cf. Isa 43:1).²⁷ And one obstacle yields to nothing but its proper key: unconfessed sin “does not clear” by any therapeutic means—“only confession does”—so that the first move in clearing thorns is discernment and sometimes simply the owning, before God and at least one other, of what has not been owned.²⁸

From this comes the lower-level pedagogy’s sharpest tool, the corpus’s *tool map*:
different knots clear by different means, and “the wrong tool” on the wrong knot “can make

²⁵IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 2, on Heb 12:1: “Sin is confessed. Weight is laid aside.” The first diagnostic task is to ask whether a given obstacle is primarily a sin problem or primarily a weight problem, because the two are cleared by different means.

²⁶IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 3 (“Believing the Lie”): “Every emotional knot has a cognitive root—a belief about God, about myself, or about others that is false.” The intermediate structure is “the vow... the wound hardened into policy.”

²⁷IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 5, drawing on Eldredge, *Wild at Heart*, that each person carries a core question the wound and the enemy target, which “the God-Connect is the only place that question gets a final answer” (cf. Isa 43:1, “I have called you by name, you are mine”).

²⁸IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 4 (“Confession and Restoration”): unconfessed sin is the one obstacle that does not yield to the other tools—“TPM does not clear unconfessed sin... Only confession does” (cf. Jas 5:16). The corpus rates this among its highest-confidence laws.

things worse.” Grief clears by the naming of unfinished communications and other business and the inner-healing work that completes them; shame, which says “I am a bad thing” where guilt says “I did a bad thing,” clears not by confession but by a revelation of identity; fear, which lives in the body before it reaches the mind, clears first through the body; anger clears through forgiveness, “the release of my claim to be the one who settles the score.”²⁹ The instruments named are concrete and drawn from established traditions—grief-recovery practice, the recovery of disowned “gold” from the shame-bearing self, somatic regulation, the discipline of forgiveness.³⁰ But the pedagogy’s governing claim is the boundary again, stated as flatly here as anywhere in either corpus: “no tool releases a knot apart from the ministry of the Spirit; the tools help create the conditions for the Spirit to work.”³¹

Two further obstacles sit precisely on the Responding-to-Valuing line, because both are forms of professed valuing that has not become real. The first is the secret doubt. A person may say a passage is true while privately withholding trust from it, and that withheld trust “is an emotional knot attached to a specific truth-claim,” which “operates as an underground brake on the faith that scripture should produce” until it is named and brought to the Spirit.³² To name the real question—rather than recite the doctrinal answer one already knows—is to attack the exact

²⁹IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 6 (“The Tool Map”): the wrong tool applied to the wrong obstacle “can make things worse”; the map matches tool to blockage along distinct dimensions (grief → Grief Recovery / inner healing; shame → identity revelation; fear → the body; anger → forgiveness; sin → confession; the believed lie → truth delivered by the Spirit).

³⁰On the grief tool, John W. James and Russell Friedman, *The Grief Recovery Handbook*, 20th anniversary expanded ed. (New York: HarperCollins, 2009); on the shame/identity tool, the “gold-and-shadow” recovery work the corpus draws from the men’s-formation tradition, including John Eldredge, *Wild at Heart: Discovering the Secret of a Man’s Soul* (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 2001), and *Waking the Dead: The Glory of a Heart Fully Alive* (Nashville: Thomas Nelson, 2003).

³¹IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 2: “No tool releases a knot apart from the ministry of the Spirit; the tools help create the conditions for the Spirit to work.” The transformation-prayer practice the corpus adopts (TPM) is framed the same way: the facilitator identifies the presenting emotion; the Spirit identifies and heals the root.

³²IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 7 (the “Any Doubts?” process): a privately held doubt “is an emotional knot attached to a specific truth-claim,” which “operates as an underground brake on the faith that scripture should produce” until it is named and brought to the Spirit. This is precisely the gap between professed valuing and actual trust.

gap between Responding (saying the word matters) and Valuing (finding that it does). The second is the idol: a good thing loved as an ultimate thing, which quietly reorders the heart around itself. The corpus treats it as its own kind of knot, diagnosed and dethroned by re-enthroning Christ in its place.³³ In every case the dynamic is the same: the heart cannot come to love the word intrinsically while its energy is mortgaged to a thorn, and so the watering of desire at this threshold is, in large part, a clearing of the ground.³⁴

What carries a heart across the line, once the thorns are thinning, is not a final technique but a turning toward obedience. The corpus's deepest operational claim is that hearing and loving the word grow by acting on it: "acting on what God has already shown you is the condition for receiving more revelation... obedience deepens love, love deepens faith, and faith increases the quality of hearing" (cf. John 7:17).³⁵ Valuing is not first felt and then enacted; it is, as often, enacted in small obedience until it is felt. The cleared ground and the obeyed word meet, and the practice the world used to sustain begins to sustain itself.

The Container and a Worked Arc

None of this is solo work, and the lower levels are where that is most evident. The corpus orders all formation as a causal sequence—Self, then Others, then God, then Mission—in which "attempts to connect with God while bypassing honest self-examination and genuine community

³³On idols as a distinct lower-level obstacle, IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 6, draws on Timothy Keller, *Counterfeit Gods: The Empty Promises of Money, Sex, and Power, and the Only Hope That Matters* (New York: Dutton, 2009); the re-enthronement move is anchored in Col 3:1–4.

³⁴This section concretizes what "Cultivating Spiritual Maturity" could only name in outline—the "watering of desire" at the Responding-to-Valuing threshold. The IJH account specifies the mechanism: much of what looks like absent desire is desire choked by an unresolved load, so that the watering is, in large part, a clearing.

³⁵IJH, Vol. 1, Exp. 6 ("The Obedience Channel," on John 7:17): "acting on what God has already shown you is the condition for receiving more revelation... obedience deepens love, love deepens faith, and faith increases the quality of hearing."

tend to produce performance rather than transformation.”³⁶ The reason is exactly the one the thorny soil exposes: the knots a person cannot see in themselves are precisely the ones others can. Confession needs a witness; the story needs a hearer; the secret doubt needs a room safe enough to be spoken in. The communal container is not a delivery mechanism for content but the condition under which the lower-level clearing can happen at all, which is why the Companions stage even confession as a community practice—after the manner of James 5:16—while carefully holding deeper inner-healing work for trained settings.³⁷

The Fellowship’s ten-week Getting Started curriculum gathers the whole pedagogy into a designed arc, and serves here as the worked illustration. Its weeks move through the corpus’s sequence: a welcome that builds the container; a Heart-Soil week; the telling of one’s story; being known; confession and restoration; the introduction of PROAPT; an experiential encounter with God; the naming of the real doubt; the discovery of mission; and a sending.³⁸ Its target is stated with unusual honesty about scope: “We are not trying to push every participant to Level 3 in ten weeks. The honest target is to get the cohort to the threshold of the Level 2-to-Level 3 transition, where intrinsic motivation begins to take over from external structure.”³⁹ The Heart-Soil week models the regions-of-one-heart reading exactly—offered as “not a test—a mirror,” on the premise that “we have all four going on,” and insisting that “good soil” is not soil without

³⁶IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 5, *Proposed Law (Structural)*: “Connecting with Self, Others, God, and Mission is a causal sequence with directional dependencies... Attempts to connect with God while bypassing honest self-examination and genuine community tend to produce performance rather than transformation.”

³⁷FotH, “Getting Started,” Week 5 (“Safe and Brave Together”) practices confession-in-community after the model of Jas 5:16, explicitly holding back the deeper inner-healing work as inappropriate for that setting; cf. IJH, Vol. 2, Exp. 4.

³⁸FotH, “Getting Started,” series index and *Companion’s Handbook*, §§1–2, 9. The ten-week arc moves Self (weeks 2–3) → Others (4–5) → God (6–8) → Mission (9) → integration (10), each session opened and closed inside the container.

³⁹FotH, “Getting Started,” *Companion’s Handbook*, §1: “We are not trying to push every participant to Level 3 in ten weeks. The honest target is to get the cohort to the threshold of the Level 2-to-Level 3 transition, where intrinsic motivation begins to take over from external structure.”

rocks or thorns but soil that “hears, accepts, and produces,” for “the point is fruit, not perfection.”⁴⁰

The Companions’ instincts at the level of detail are the instincts this article has been commending. Its between-session practice for the soil week is a discipline of noticing without fixing—“no fixing—we are noticing; the Spirit fixes”—and its assessment is light, narrative, and adapted from the testing framework of the parent corpus.⁴¹ Its leader is renamed a *Companion* and deliberately de-centered—“the page is a floor under your feet, not a script you read from”—the receding presence the second companion study described, here serving the lower levels.⁴² A cohort may complete the series and stop, and that ending is honored; the aim is never to manufacture a higher level but to leave the lower ground genuinely cleared and the threshold genuinely in view.

Implications and Conclusion

This article has argued that formation in the lower three levels is governed by a rule of its own: in the lower levels, cultivate by clearing, and match the clearing tool to the soil condition. The hard path is plowed and prayed over; the rocky ground is deepened by rhythm and by being known; the thorny ground is cleared, knot by knot, of the loads that choke desire—and only then does the threshold into Valuing come into reach. The rule is the lower-level instance of the

⁴⁰FotH, “Getting Started,” Week 2 (“The Soil of Your Heart”): the diagnostic is offered as “not a test—a mirror,” and the reframe is “We’re not asking, ‘Are you the path or the rocky soil?’ ... We have all four going on.” On good soil: “He does not say good soil never has rocks or thorns. He says good soil hears, accepts, and produces. The point is fruit, not perfection.”

⁴¹FotH, “Getting Started,” Week 2 between-session practice: “No fixing—we are noticing. The Spirit fixes.” On assessment, the Companions use light, narrative-biased instruments (a pre-series survey, the journal, a mid-series pulse at week 5, a post-series reflection), adapted from IJH, Vol. 4, §3.

⁴²FotH renames the leader a “Companion” (not a facilitator), de-centered in favor of the Spirit: the handbook tells the Companion, “the page is a floor under your feet, not a script you read from.” Cf. the receding-presence account of the small-group leader in “Cultivating Spiritual Maturity.”

principle the whole series shares: means matched to condition, applied where the Spirit is pleased to use them. Beneath the path the same rule reaches its gravest form: where the ground is not merely hard but actively contested—a Level -1, in which a heart works against others’ receiving as well as its own—the Companion’s first work is to discern the contest and the second is to engage it in prayer and in company, never alone, and never apart from being companioned and directed oneself.

Three implications follow. First, the soil is one heart. Read with the corpus as four co-present regions rather than four people or four stages, the Sower stops being a ladder and becomes a mirror—dissolving the over-allegory objection, grounding the integration-not-replacement reading, and making plain that the lower levels are not a vestibule but ground that must stay open for life. Second, the threshold into Valuing is crossed by subtraction more than addition. The corpus’s account of the emotional knot specifies what the second companion study could only name: much of what presents as absent desire is desire obstructed, so that the watering of the duty-to-desire transition is largely a clearing of thorns and a turning toward obedience. Third, the lower levels are communal by necessity, because the knots a heart cannot see are the ones a trusted other can—so the container is not optional infrastructure but the condition of the work.

The series’ governing boundary holds at every step of the descent. The honest entry cannot create willingness; the rhythm cannot manufacture delight; the tools cannot release a knot; confession opens a door it does not itself walk through. “No tool releases a knot apart from the ministry of the Spirit,” the corpus says of its own practice, and the Companions say it more simply still to a roomful of beginners: “we are noticing; the Spirit fixes.” The lower-level

worker's task is the gardener's humblest—to read the ground, bring the fitting tool, clear what can be cleared, and wait.

What remains above this article is the upper half. A further companion would take up Organization and Characterization, where, by the testimony of both bodies of work, cultivation gives way almost wholly to duration, to suffering, and to the Spirit's unhurried completing of what the lower clearing only began.⁴³ But the lower ground is where most disciples live and most ministry labors, and it repays the most careful attention precisely because it is so easily mishandled. The seed cannot be made to grow. The ground can be cleared. Clearing it well—path, rock, and thorn—so that when the word falls it can finally take root, is the whole of the lower-level art, and it ends where all the others end: in the open-handed waiting of those who have done what they can and trust the One who gives what they cannot.

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⁴³ A future companion would treat the upper two levels—Organization (Level 4) and Characterization (Level 5)—where, as both IJH and "Cultivating Spiritual Maturity" argue, cultivation gives way almost entirely to duration, suffering, and the Spirit's unhurried work.

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